approach to socialising, plus the way I bowl, is making me a hard figure to read for all the stalwarts in the dressing room. I'm finding myself hard to read. I am a collection of fizzing nerves, all this psychedelic information on the life of a Test cricketer unfolding in front of me. I just sit there, trying to watch, pick up who sits where and how the rhythm of it all works. I have been in the company of the one-day side on tour, but there's something about the *whites*, about this being *Test cricket*, that this is very definitely, actually *Lord's*, which is giving it all a surreal glow.

Darren Gough opens his cricket bag – a huge coffin full of gear, new and old – and over his shoulder I see he has a list of leading Test wicket-takers marked inside it, written down in permanent marker. Some names are crossed off. I realise, without wanting to give away that I'm looking too hard, that he is ticking off the bowlers he has gone past in world cricket. *I have no Test wickets*, I think to myself, the inside of his bag appearing like Mount Rushmore as I squint to read who is on there. It is obvious there is a rivalry between him and his fast bowling partner, Andy Caddick. They do not sit together. Nothing is said; there is just an energy there where you can feel that inside this room are all kinds of different loaded, personal and pressurised competitions.

As we get ready for the first morning's play, there is not a coldness per se, but a tension that I haven't experienced in a dressing room before. I look around it, scanning it for safe places, maybe next to Ashley Giles? Perhaps Steve Harmison or Matthew Hoggard? I come to realise there is no one remotely my age. This is not the kind of age difference as reassurance that I had been tractor-beamed towards at Smackwater Jack's ground floor, or the sort of coming of age, lessons of life way I experienced in the Lancashire packs, who prioritised bringing in younger players. Here, there is a wariness; a sense that there is something precious to be lost here, that there is sacred ground that must be protected. Nasser Hussain and Duncan Fletcher have been hauling the England side into a new era for four years. Their considerable, if still gradual, upward curve is not to do with freedom of expression or the joys of being a group. It is about not losing. It is about having the stomach to fight and resist and after English cricket has been criticised heavily for so long, all the players in there, heroes to me, look slightly worn, wary, jaded, all talking themselves silently into going back out to fight another round. The inconsistency in selection for the many